



Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs

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Opening remarks 2026 ECOSOC Humanitarian Affairs Segment

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UN Secretariat, ECOSOC Chamber

[AS DELIVERED]

Well, thank you, Ambassador and Excellencies, colleagues, friends, and partners.

For over a year, you have heard me saying that the humanitarian system is overstretched, underfunded and under attack.

Today, the challenge that we face collectively goes further.

The question is no longer how we respond.

It is whether we can respond at the scale and speed that people need.

Our question to you today is this: is help coming?

Because the world around us is shifting – fast.

Technology reshaping conflict.

Politics fragmenting.

Rules are ignored.

Protections are eroding.

And the humanitarian mission itself is being contested.

We are operating in environments which are more complex, more constrained and more dangerous than ever before.

The past three years have been the deadliest on record for humanitarian workers.

Over 1,000 of our colleagues killed.

And we renew our sense of commitment to this humanitarian mission in their memory and in their honor.

These are not trends.

They are lives.

The child who goes without a meal.

The patient who cannot reach a clinic.

The family forced once again to flee.

On my visits to the frontlines over the past year, I have met those people again and again. And they ask me: is help coming?

This year, we aim to reach 87 million people with life-saving support.

Not because needs have fallen – 252 million people still require aid – but because resources have plummeted.

And that leaves us with the hardest decision humanitarians face: who we can reach – and who we cannot reach.

The gap, though, is no longer just between needs and funding.

It is between needs and our ability, our willingness to act.

Those who pay the price are those already closest to the edge.

Families making impossible choices.

Children going hungry.

Clinics closing.

Water running dry.

Women and girls exposed to violence, exploitation and abuse.

And so, we ask again: is help coming?

Because we cannot accept this as the new normal.

Not for the people who we serve.

Not under the humanitarian imperative.

And not for our collective conscience.

This is not only a test for our humanitarian system.

It is a test for all of us.

And that is why we begin this Humanitarian Affairs Segment with the Humanitarian Reset.

Because the world has changed and we must change with it.

Over the past year, we have prioritized harder, cut bureaucracy and duplication, and pushed decision-making much closer to people we serve.

But reform is not retreat.

The choices we make reflect constraints – not diminished need.

The principle of humanity remains unchanged: we must help people wherever they are.

The Humanitarian Reset is about defending that principle under unprecedented and sustained pressure.

Our second discussion, as part of the Humanitarian Affairs Segment, focuses on international humanitarian law.

Because there is no humanitarian action without it.

Access.

Principles.

Protection of aid workers.

These are not abstractions.

They determine whether we can reach people at all.

And there is no delivering without defending.

So, we will defend, firmly, the values at the heart of humanitarian action: impartiality, neutrality, independence.

Our third discussion in our conversations over the next few days is, of course, about funding.

Without resources, there is no response at scale.

We have received now \$9.3 billion, updated this morning, of the \$23 billion required to save 87 million lives.

This is of course less than one per cent of global defense spending right now.

But humanity is not measured only in dollars and pledges and commitments.

We pay tribute also to the countries and communities often carrying the heaviest burdens themselves, who continue to open their doors and provide safety and refuge to people forced to flee.

We know that the resources exist.

The question is how we choose to use them.

Because budgets are not numbers.

They are choices.

And the future of humanitarian action will not be decided by humanitarians alone.

Parties to conflict must uphold international law.

States must protect humanitarian space.

Donors, development partners and the private sector must invest in resilience.

In a fragmented world, humanitarian action remains proof that collective action is still possible.

So far we have already reached nearly 23 million people with life-saving support, even facing the unprecedented pressures that we do.

And I can reassure you and commit to you that we can reach many more.

This conversation this week during the Humanitarian Affairs Segment is where we decide whether we will do so.

Because saving lives, reducing suffering and protecting dignity is not optional.

It is our shared responsibility.

Our shared humanity.

And so, I leave you with that question: is help coming?

Thank you.